he is in his chair, waiting for the other guy to clear up, or make a fateful mistake.

Andy Flower cut to the chase in the team meeting on the fifth morning. 'Lads,' he said, 'we haven't saved this game yet. Cookie and Trotty. You've got a responsibility to set the tone. That first hour is so crucial. If we get through that they'll start to go. You know the job isn't done yet.'

There we were, straight back under the pump. Little more than twelve hours after sitting contentedly in that dressing room, nerves were kicking in. We were on the edge of the precipice again, living on the thinnest of lines, operating on the finest of margins. It is stressful, but seductive. Of course, it is uncomfortable. That lack of comfort is comforting, if that makes sense.

Someone unaccustomed to high-performance sport might criticize Flower's intervention as a coach applying unnecessary pressure. I regarded it as a routine reminder, a statement of the obvious. I did have a responsibility to others. It was my turn to carry the load, just as others carried me when I was out of nick. It is the essence of being an individual in a team game.

Australian culture is built on the concept of mateship, an acceptance of unconditional assistance that historians have traced back to the first days of settlement. The term was even considered for inclusion in the Constitution. I have huge respect for that aspect of their national heritage, and identify with it strongly, because it distils an important element of what we do for a living.

We walk miles in one another's shoes. Deeply hidden aspects of Trotty's character emerged only in extremis, but I had a natural affinity with him when he described the experience of playing well as a drug. During a long innings we're all chasing the dragon, the natural high of excelling without conscious effort. The craving fluctuates, as pressure surges and recedes.

The rearguard action in Brisbane was a case in point. Trotty was in the nineties just before lunch on the fifth day. I got a couple of bad balls and suddenly accelerated to 197 not out. I could see him looking at me intently. His inner monologue might as well have been written in neon, across his forehead: 'I wish I'd get one of those …'

It was a flat wicket. We were well set, against an old Kookaburra ball. Yet he suddenly became a little skittish. I got to 199, clipped what should have been a simple single into the leg side to bring up my double hundred,